

ARISTOTLE

Political Theories

★ A Comprehensive Academic Study ★

384–322 BCE

Containing: Theories • Explanations • Flowcharts • Original Quotations • Comparative Analysis

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1. Theory of the State (Polis)

Overview & Origin

Aristotle's theory of the State, elaborated primarily in his Politics, is the cornerstone of Western political philosophy. Unlike his teacher Plato, who treated the State as an artificial creation of a philosopher-king's reason, Aristotle regarded the State as a natural organism that grows from simpler associations and fulfils human nature's highest potential.

“Every state is a community of some kind, and every community is established with a view to some good; for mankind always act in order to obtain that which they think good.”

— Aristotle, Politics, Book I, Chapter 1

The Natural Origin of the State

Aristotle traces the evolution of the state through successive natural communities, each progressively more complex and complete than the last. This evolutionary logic is one of the earliest teleological theories in political science — the idea that nature aims at the highest end.

FLOWCHART: Natural Evolution of the State

(Read top to bottom — each stage emerges naturally from the previous)

STAGE 1: The Family (Oikos)

Man + Woman + Children — Natural union for daily needs “The family is the association established by nature for the supply of men’s everyday wants.”



STAGE 2: The Village (Kome)

Several families united for more than daily needs Settled community, sharing goods, protection, and customs



STAGE 3: The Polis (City-State)

Several villages united into a complete, self-sufficing community The highest form of association — fulfils human nature



TELOS (Final Purpose)

The Good Life — Eudaimonia (Flourishing) Only in the Polis can humans achieve their full moral & rational potential

Key Characteristics of Aristotle's State

Essential Features of the Polis

- Self-sufficiency (Autarkeia): The Polis alone meets all human needs — physical, social, moral, and intellectual.
- Natural Entity: The Polis is not a social contract or artificial creation; it exists by nature.
- Priority over Individual: The whole is prior to its parts — the Polis is prior to the individual and the family.
- Common Good (Koinon Agathon): The goal of the state is the happiness and virtue of its citizens, not the ruler's private interest.
- Size Matters: The ideal state must be small enough for citizens to know each other personally, but large enough to be self-sufficient.

The State as Natural vs. Contractarian Views

Aristotle's Organic View	Social Contract View (e.g., Hobbes/Rousseau)
The State is natural — humans are political animals by nature.	The State is artificial — created by agreement to escape the state of nature.
Political life is the fulfilment of human nature.	Political life is a necessary constraint on natural freedom.
The common good is the state's inherent purpose.	The state protects individual rights and interests.
The individual is incomplete outside the Polis.	The individual is complete in the state of nature.

“Hence it is evident that the polis is a creation of nature, and that man is by nature a political animal.”

— Aristotle, Politics, Book I, Chapter 2

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2. Theory of Human Nature & Zoon Politikon

The Political Animal

Aristotle's assertion that man is a Zoon Politikon — a political animal — is arguably the single most quoted sentence in political science. It encapsulates his entire view of human nature, ethics, and the purpose of political association. Far from being simply a social creature, man is by nature adapted to life in the structured moral community of the Polis.

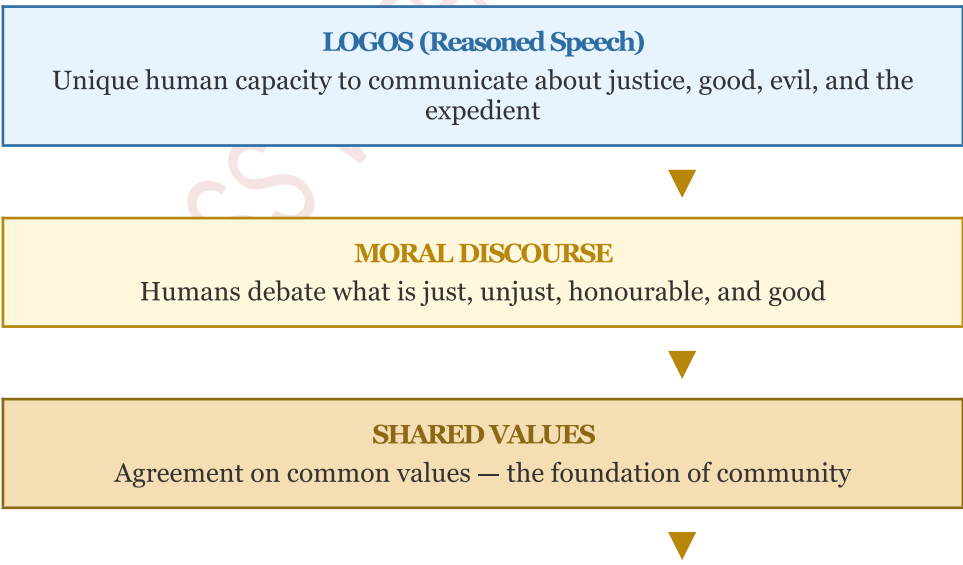
“Man is by nature a political animal. It is evident that man is a political animal, more political than any bee or any herd animal.”

— Aristotle, *Politics*, Book I, Chapter 2

What Does 'Political Animal' Mean?

The phrase is often misunderstood as simply 'social animal.' Aristotle makes a deeper point: while bees and herd animals are social, only humans possess the gift of logos — reasoned speech — which enables them to communicate about justice, injustice, good, and evil. It is this capacity for moral discourse that makes political life not merely possible but necessary for human fulfilment.

FLOWCHART: From Human Nature to the Political Community



THE POLIS

Moral community that expresses and perfects human nature



EUDAIMONIA

The Good Life — the natural telos of every human being

Three Categories of Beings Outside the Polis

Who Lives Outside Political Society? (Aristotle's Taxonomy)

- The Beast: A creature too brutish, violent, or base to live by law — sub-human in moral capacity.
- The God: A being so self-sufficient and perfect that it needs no community — supra-human.
- The Outcast/Misfit: Someone who through accident or misfortune has been expelled from political life.
- KEY POINT: Only an abnormal human — whether below or above human nature — can live without the Polis.

“He who is unable to live in society, or who has no need because he is sufficient for himself, must be either a beast or a god.”

— Aristotle, *Politics*, Book I, Chapter 2

3. Theory of Citizenship

Defining the Citizen

For Aristotle, citizenship is not merely a legal status. A citizen, in the true and unqualified sense, participates directly in the deliberative and judicial offices of the state. This active participation in ruling and being ruled distinguishes genuine citizens from mere residents, slaves, or foreigners.

“He who has the power to take part in the deliberative or judicial administration of any state is said by us to be a citizen of that state.”

— Aristotle, *Politics*, Book III, Chapter 1

Criteria of Citizenship

Criterion	Description	Who Qualifies
Participation in Rule	Holding office, voting, deliberating in the assembly	Free adult male citizens
Share in Justice	Access to courts as juror or litigant	Citizens of the Polis
Parentage	Born of citizen parents (both mother and father)	By birth-right
Service & Virtue	Military service and moral virtue	The virtuous free man

Types of Citizenship

Aristotle's Gradations of Citizenship

- Full Citizen (Polites): Participates in deliberation and adjudication — the only true citizen in an ideal state.
- Partial Citizen: Participates only in some offices (e.g., serving on a jury but not holding magistracy).
- Honorary Citizen: Granted citizenship as a privilege — not a full participant by nature.
- Excluded Groups: Women, slaves, metics (resident aliens), artisans, and labourers — excluded from full citizenship in most Greek constitutions.

The Good Citizen vs. The Good Man

The Good Citizen	The Good Man
Virtue relative to the constitution he lives under.	Absolute virtue — complete moral excellence.
Fulfils specific civic duties and roles.	Fulfils the requirements of rational and moral perfection.
Different virtues in different constitutions.	The same single, perfect virtue everywhere.
Good citizen possible in a bad constitution.	Good man is always good, regardless of context.
Aristotle says these only coincide in the ideal state.	Only in the best Polis do the good man and good citizen merge.

“The virtue of the good citizen and the virtue of the good man cannot be the same for all citizens; but the virtue of the good citizen must be the virtue of the best state.”

— Aristotle, Politics, Book III, Chapter 4

4. Classification of Governments (Constitutions)

Aristotle's Sixfold Classification

Aristotle's classification of constitutions in Book III of Politics is one of the most enduring frameworks in political science. He combines two criteria — the number of rulers and whether the rulers govern for the common good or for private interest — to produce six types of government.

Number of Rulers	One	Few	Many
Rule for Common Good ✓	MONARCHY (Kingship)	ARISTOCRACY	POLITY (Constitutional Govt)
Rule for Private Interest ✗	TYRANNY	OLIGARCHY	DEMOCRACY (Extreme)

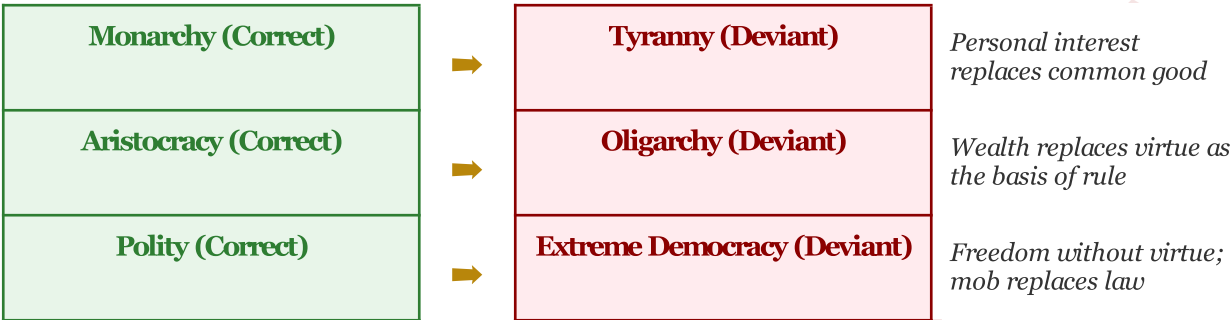
Detailed Descriptions

Form	Type	Rulers	Basis	Aristotle's Verdict
Monarchy	Correct	One	Virtue & wisdom of the king	Best if the king is truly virtuous; rare and unstable
Aristocracy	Correct	Few	Merit & virtue of the elite	Excellent in theory; often slides into oligarchy in practice
Polity	Correct	Many	Property & civic virtue of the middle class	Most practical best — the mixed constitution Aristotle recommends
Tyranny	Deviant	One	Ruler's personal self-interest	Worst of all — the greatest perversion
Oligarchy	Deviant	Few	Wealth of the rich	Rule of the rich for the rich — unjust and unstable
Democracy	Deviant	Many	Freedom; numerical majority	Rule of the poor for the poor — a lesser evil than oligarchy or tyranny

“Of the above-mentioned forms, the perversions are as follows: of royalty, tyranny; of aristocracy, oligarchy; of constitutional government, democracy.”

— Aristotle, Politics, Book III, Chapter 7

FLOWCHART: Correct Forms and Their Perversions



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5. Theory of the Best Polity (Mixed Constitution)

The Practical Ideal: Polity

While Aristotle recognised monarchy and aristocracy as theoretically superior forms, he argued that the most practically achievable and stable best constitution is the Polity — a mixed constitution combining elements of oligarchy and democracy, anchored by a strong middle class. This represents Aristotle's empirical genius: the best constitution for actual humans in actual conditions.

“The best political community is formed by citizens of the middle class, and that those states are likely to be well-administered in which the middle class is large.”

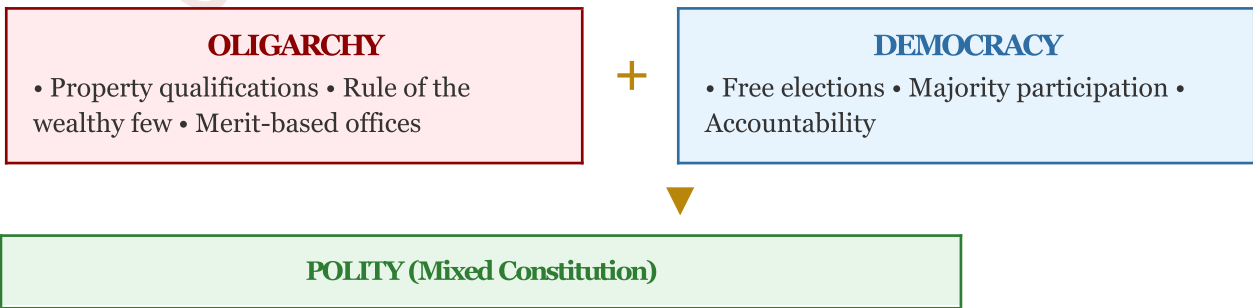
— Aristotle, Politics, Book IV, Chapter 11

Elements of the Mixed Constitution

How Polity Blends Democracy and Oligarchy

- From Democracy: Majority participation, elections, accountability of officials, freedom of citizens.
- From Oligarchy: Property qualification for higher offices, merit-based selection for key roles.
- The Balance: Neither the extreme poor (who may envy the rich) nor the extreme rich (who may become arrogant) should dominate.
- The Middle Class: Acts as moderator — neither too ambitious nor too resentful — ensuring stability.
- Rule of Law: The constitution itself governs, not individual rulers — law is supreme.

FLOWCHART: Structure of the Mixed Constitution (Polity)



Governed by the middle class • Rule of Law • Moderation & Stability



THE GOOD LIFE (Eudaimonia)

Justice • Virtue • Prosperity • Stability for all citizens

“In all states there are three elements: one class is very rich, another very poor, and a third in a mean. It is admitted that moderation and the mean are best.”

— Aristotle, Politics, Book IV, Chapter 11

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6. Theory of Justice

Justice as the Bond of the Political Community

Aristotle's theory of justice, developed in the Nicomachean Ethics (Book V) and echoed throughout Politics, is one of the most sophisticated analyses of the concept in the history of philosophy. For Aristotle, justice is the highest political virtue — the bond that holds the political community together.

“Justice is the bond of men in states, for the administration of justice, which is the determination of what is just, is the principle of order in political society.”

— Aristotle, Politics, Book I, Chapter 2

Types of Justice

Aristotle's Classification of Justice

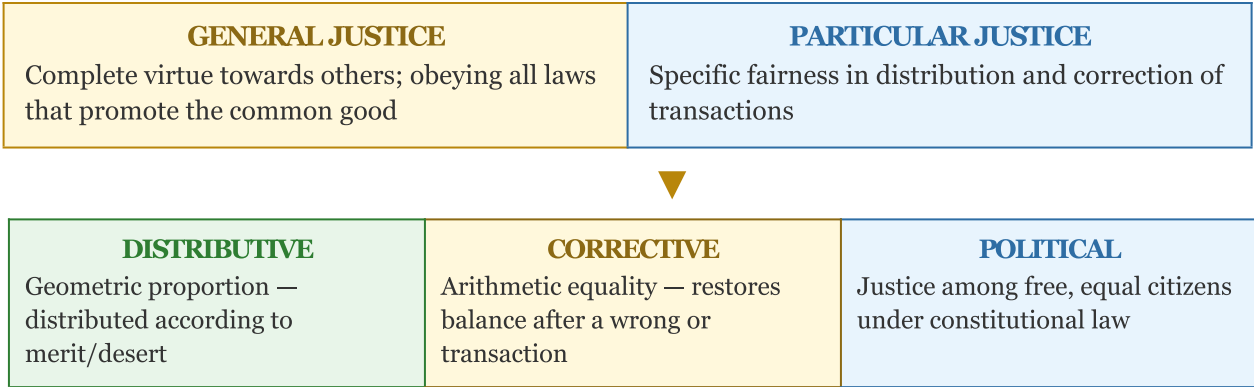
- General (Universal) Justice: Complete virtue towards others — the whole of moral virtue as it applies in social relations.
- Particular Justice: A specific virtue dealing with distribution and rectification of particular goods and harms.
- Distributive Justice: Proportional distribution of honours, wealth, and goods according to merit (desert).
- Corrective (Rectificatory) Justice: Restoring balance in voluntary and involuntary transactions — arithmetic equality.
- Reciprocal Justice (Exchange): Justice in economic exchange — the basis of commercial society.
- Political Justice: Justice among free and equal citizens under a constitution — the most complete form.

FLOWCHART: Aristotle's Theory of Justice

JUSTICE (Dikaiosyne)

The supreme political virtue — treating others according to what they deserve





Distributive Justice: The Core Principle

Aristotle's principle of distributive justice holds that equals should be treated equally, and unequals unequally — but in proportion to their relevant differences. This geometric or proportional equality distinguishes Aristotle from modern egalitarian theories. Honours and offices should go to those with the greatest virtue and merit.

“If persons are not equal, they will not have equal shares; it is when equals have or are given unequal shares, or persons not equal equal shares, that quarrels and complaints arise.”

— Aristotle, *Nicomachean Ethics*, Book V, Chapter 3

7. Theory of Rule of Law

Law Over Men

Aristotle is the father of the Rule of Law doctrine in Western political thought. His central argument is that law — as the embodiment of reason and the common good — is a superior ruler to any individual human being, however virtuous, because law is free from passion and personal interest.

“He who bids the law rule may be deemed to bid God and Reason alone rule, but he who bids man rule adds an element of the beast; for desire is a wild beast, and passion perverts the minds of rulers.”

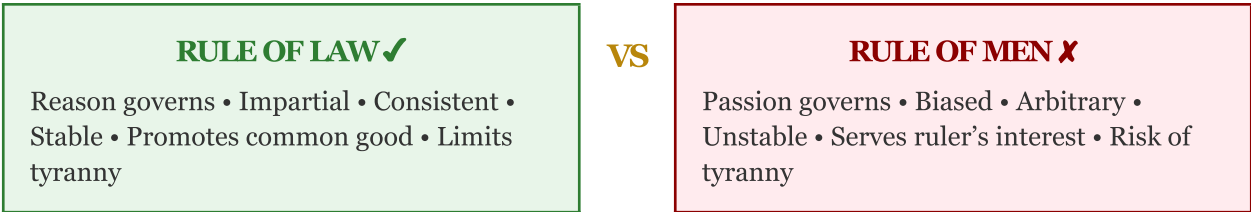
— Aristotle, Politics, Book III, Chapter 16

Arguments for the Rule of Law

Why Law Must Rule, Not Men (Aristotle's Reasoning)

- Law is Reason Without Passion: A good law embodies universal reason, purged of emotional bias and self-interest.
- Men Are Subject to Passion: Even the best rulers can be corrupted by fear, ambition, greed, or favouritism.
- Consistency and Predictability: Law applies the same standard to all, ensuring fairness and enabling citizens to plan their lives.
- Accumulation of Wisdom: Laws represent the collective wisdom of many generations — wiser than any single man.
- Legitimacy: Citizens obey law willingly because they see it as impartial; obedience to a man feels like subjugation.

FLOWCHART: Rule of Law vs. Rule of Men



Limits of the Rule of Law

Aristotle acknowledged that law cannot cover every particular situation. When the law falls short, the ruler must use practical wisdom (phronesis) to decide equitably. But this discretion is itself governed by the spirit of the law and the end of the common good — it is not unchecked personal will.

“Therefore the law is reason unaffected by desire.”

— Aristotle, *Politics*, Book III, Chapter 16

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8. Theory of Education & Its Political Role

Education as the Pillar of the State

Aristotle devoted Books VII and VIII of Politics to education, arguing that it is the single most important function of the state. Without a proper system of public education, no constitution can be preserved. Citizens must be shaped by education to fit the spirit of the constitution they live under.

“The legislator should direct his attention above all to the education of youth; for the neglect of education does harm to the constitution.”

— Aristotle, Politics, Book VIII, Chapter 1

Key Principles of Aristotle's Theory of Education

Aristotle's Educational Philosophy

- **Public and Compulsory:** Education must be a public function — too important to be left to private families.
- **Common Education for Common Goals:** Since there is one aim for the whole state, education must be the same for all citizens.
- **Moral Formation:** The primary goal of education is virtue — shaping the character (ethos) of citizens toward the good life.
- **Physical Education First:** The body must be trained before the mind — gymnasium (physical training) precedes academic learning.
- **Music and the Arts:** Music educates the emotions and habituates the soul toward virtuous pleasure — a vital civic tool.
- **Intellectual Education:** Reading, writing, and drawing round out the educated citizen — skills useful for civic life.

FLOWCHART: Stages of Education According to Aristotle

INFANCY (0-7 years)

Habituation to good habits • Play • Physical development
Parents responsible; avoid bad habits and harsh labour



EARLY EDUCATION (7-14 years)

Physical training (gymnastics) • Music • Drawing Body trained before mind;
habits of virtue formed



ADOLESCENT EDUCATION (14-21 years)

Academic learning • Logic • Science • Philosophy Reason awakens;
intellectual virtues cultivated



CIVIC PARTICIPATION

Military service • Public office • Civic deliberation Virtue perfected through
active political life

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9. Theory of Slavery

Natural Slavery: Aristotle's Controversial Doctrine

Aristotle's theory of natural slavery is one of the most debated and criticised aspects of his political philosophy. He argued in Politics Book I that some human beings are by nature slaves — suited by their rational and physical constitution to be instruments of others. This theory must be understood in its historical context while being assessed critically.

“He is by nature a slave who is capable of belonging to another — and he who participates in rational principle enough to apprehend, but not to have, such a principle, is a slave by nature.”

— Aristotle, Politics, Book I, Chapter 5

Natural Slave vs. Conventional Slave

Natural Slave (Aristotle's Concept)	Conventional Slave (Historical Reality)
Lacks full rational capacity — can understand commands but cannot deliberate.	Enslaved by conquest, war, or debt — may be fully rational.
Slavery is beneficial and just for the natural slave.	Slavery by convention may be unjust.
The slave is a living instrument, part of the master's household.	The slave is a person reduced to property by circumstance.
Aristotle considered this a natural division within humanity.	Aristotle himself acknowledged this distinction was hard to identify in practice.

Critical Assessment

Modern Critique of Aristotle's Theory of Slavery

- Aristotle himself admitted there is no reliable way to identify a natural slave by appearance — his theory was practically circular.
- The argument that some people lack full rational capacity to justify their enslavement was used for centuries to oppress conquered and colonised peoples.

- Many ancient critics (and later philosophers like Rousseau) rejected natural slavery entirely, arguing all humans possess reason equally.
- Aristotle's theory reflects the social prejudices of 4th century BCE Athens, not a universally valid scientific claim.
- Despite this, Aristotle's framework distinguishes natural slavery from mere conventional slavery — a distinction that was philosophically sharper than most ancient thinking.

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10. Theory of Revolution & Political Stability

Why Revolutions Occur

Books V and VI of Politics constitute the most comprehensive ancient analysis of political change, revolution (stasis), and the preservation of constitutions. Aristotle combines empirical observation (he studied 158 constitutions) with theoretical analysis to explain why regimes fall and how they can be preserved.

“The universal and chief cause of this revolutionary feeling has been already mentioned; viz., the desire of equality, when men think that they are equal to others who have more than themselves.”

— Aristotle, Politics, Book V, Chapter 2

Primary Causes of Revolution

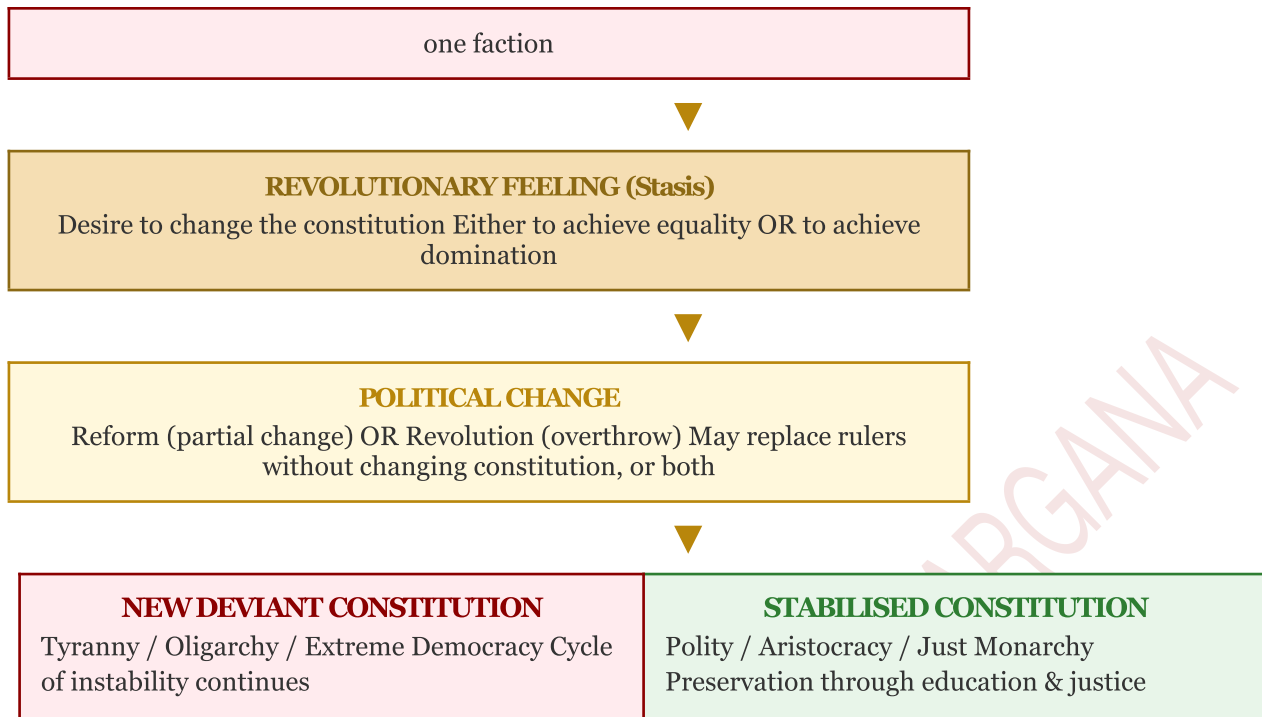
Aristotle's Taxonomy of Revolutionary Causes

- Inequality: Perceived injustice in the distribution of wealth, honour, or power — the deepest root of political conflict.
- Insolence and Contempt: The arrogance of the ruling class breeds resentment among the governed.
- Fear: Both fear of punishment and fear of loss of power drive groups to revolt preemptively.
- Disproportionate Growth of a Part: When one class (the rich or poor) grows too powerful, the balance collapses.
- Election Manipulation: Disputes over elections and appointments erode constitutional legitimacy.
- Neglect of Small Changes: Constitutions are subverted gradually by seemingly small violations that accumulate.
- Racial and Tribal Diversity: Multi-ethnic states prone to faction and conflict — unity of character matters.

FLOWCHART: Causes, Process, and Prevention of Revolution

ROOT CAUSES

Inequality • Injustice • Arrogance of rulers Fear • Disproportionate power of



How to Preserve Constitutions

Aristotle's Prescriptions for Constitutional Stability

- Obedience to the Law: The spirit of the constitution must be maintained — small violations accumulate into regime collapse.
- Public Education: Citizens must be educated in the values of the constitution they live under.
- Watch the Middle Class: Ensure the middle class remains large — they prevent polarisation between rich and poor.
- Avoid Extremes: Neither extreme democracy nor extreme oligarchy is stable — moderation in all things.
- Treat the Opposition Well: Give minority groups a stake in the system so they do not become revolutionary.
- Rotation of Offices: No individual or group should hold power indefinitely — rotation prevents tyranny.
- Good Governance: Honest, capable, and just administration reduces grievances that fuel revolution.

11. Theory of Virtue & the Ethical Basis of Politics

Ethics and Politics as One Science

Aristotle saw ethics and politics as inseparable. Politics is the master science that directs all other sciences toward the highest human good — eudaimonia. Ethics (the study of individual virtue) is the foundation of politics (the science of the common good). A state of unjust people cannot be a good state; a state that does not cultivate virtue cannot produce good people.

“Since our predecessors have left the subject of legislation to us unexamined, it is perhaps best that we should ourselves study it, and in general study the question of what form of political science can complete the philosophy of human nature.”

— Aristotle, Nicomachean Ethics, Book X, Chapter 9

The Doctrine of the Mean (Mesotes)

At the heart of Aristotle's ethics is the famous Doctrine of the Mean — virtue is the intermediate between two extremes (excess and deficiency). This applies in politics: the ideal constitution is the mean between oligarchy and democracy; the ideal citizen possesses virtues that are means between vices.

Deficiency (Vice)	Virtue (Mean)	Excess (Vice)
Cowardice	Courage	Recklessness
Miserliness	Generosity	Prodigality
Boorishness	Wit / Humour	Buffoonery
Deficiency of Honour	Proper Pride	Vanity
Injustice (giving too little)	Justice	Injustice (taking too much)
Extreme Oligarchy	Polity (Mean)	Extreme Democracy

“Virtue, then, is a state of character concerned with choice, lying in a mean, i.e., the mean relative to us, this being determined by a rational principle.”

— Aristotle, *Nicomachean Ethics*, Book II, Chapter 6

Political Implications of Virtue Ethics

How Virtue Ethics Shapes Aristotle's Political Theory

- The purpose of the state is to produce virtuous citizens — not just safe or prosperous ones.
- Rulers must be virtuous: practical wisdom (phronesis) is the chief virtue of the statesman.
- Laws must be designed to habituate citizens toward virtue — law shapes character.
- The best constitution produces citizens who possess the mean — neither excessively rich nor desperately poor.
- Eudaimonia (flourishing) — the political goal — is activity in accordance with complete virtue.

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12. Theory of the Middle Class & Balanced Society

The Middle Class as the Political Backbone

Aristotle's analysis of the political role of the middle class in Book IV of Politics is arguably the most original and enduring contribution of his political sociology. He argued that states dominated by a large, strong middle class are the most stable, most just, and most likely to achieve the good life for all citizens.

“It is manifest that the best political community is formed by citizens of the middle class, and that those states are likely to be well-administered, in which the middle class is large and stronger if possible than both the other classes.”

— Aristotle, Politics, Book IV, Chapter 11

Why the Middle Class is Superior

The Very Rich	The Middle Class	The Very Poor
Insolent, contemptuous of others	Neither arrogant nor servile	Degraded, servile, resentful
Unwilling to obey; want to dominate	Willing to both rule and obey	Incapable of ruling; submit to demagogues
Commit crimes through excess	Lead a life of moderation and virtue	Commit crimes through want
Destabilise through oligarchic faction	Stabilise by moderating extremes	Destabilise through mob politics
Hard to govern; seek to monopolise	Easiest to govern by reason	Easily manipulated by demagogues

FLOWCHART: The Middle Class and Political Stability



WEAK MIDDLE CLASS → INSTABILITY Polarisation • Faction • Revolution • Tyranny	STRONG MIDDLE CLASS → STABILITY Moderation • Justice • Polity • Eudaimonia
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Relevance to Modern Political Science

Aristotle's theory of the middle class anticipates modern sociological research on political stability. Barrington Moore, Robert Dahl, and Lipset's modernisation theory all confirm what Aristotle observed 2,400 years ago: a strong middle class is the social foundation of stable democratic governance. Aristotle's insight remains one of the most empirically verified propositions in comparative politics.

Summary: Aristotle's Political Theories at a Glance

Theory	Core Claim	Key Text
Theory of the State	The Polis is natural; humans are political animals fulfilling their telos in it.	Politics, Book I
Zoon Politikon	Man is a political animal by nature; logos enables moral community.	Politics, Book I
Citizenship	True citizen participates in ruling and being ruled; good citizen differs from good man.	Politics, Book III
Classification of Govt	Six forms: 3 correct (monarchy, aristocracy, polity) and 3 deviant (tyranny, oligarchy, democracy).	Politics, Book III
Best Polity	Mixed constitution anchored by middle class is the practically best government.	Politics, Book IV
Justice	Distributive (proportional) and corrective (arithmetic) justice; the bond of the Polis.	N. Ethics, Book V
Rule of Law	Law (reason without passion) must govern, not individual men.	Politics, Book III
Education	Public education shapes virtue; essential to preserve any constitution.	Politics, Book VIII

Slavery	Natural slaves lack full rational capacity; controversial and criticised doctrine.	Politics, Book I
Revolution	Inequality and injustice cause revolution; virtue, law, and middle class prevent it.	Politics, Book V
Virtue Ethics	Virtue is the mean; politics must cultivate virtue for eudaimonia.	N. Ethics, Book II
Middle Class	Strong middle class = political stability, justice, and the best polity.	Politics, Book IV

Primary Sources: Aristotle, Politics (trans. Benjamin Jowett); Nicomachean Ethics (trans. W.D. Ross); Constitution of Athens.